



15 MILES

THE HEIGHT OF THE ERUPTION COLUMN IN THE MOUNT ST. HELENS EXPLOSION

Mount St. Helens in Washington State erupted, with a massive avalanche in May, and a cloud of ash that screened out all sunlight as far as 250 miles (400 km) away.

ROBERT MUGABE WON A SWEEPING VICTORY on March 4, becoming prime minister of **Rhodesia**. A Marxist guerrilla fighter, he was hated by Ian Smith's white-minority regime. On April 18, Rhodesia became **Zimbabwe**.

Parts of **Africa** suffered extreme deprivation due to **famine** in 1980. Drought, cattle raiding, and a breakdown in civil order caused a food shortage. The **famine in Uganda** is regarded as one of the worst in history—21 percent of the population died.

Smallpox was declared **extinct** on May 8 by the World Health Organization, 21 years after the global eradication program had begun. The last natural case of smallpox was in Somalia in October 1977. Around **300 million**

people died from smallpox in the 20th century alone. The **Iranian Embassy in London** became involved in a dramatic siege on April 30, when



Smallpox eradication
A global vaccination campaign led to WHO declaring smallpox eradicated in 1980. Smallpox was a devastating illness, with a mortality rate of 30%.

six gunmen from a group opposed to **Ayatollah Khomeini** took over the building. They demanded the release of 91 Iranian political prisoners. The siege ended after a raid by the **Special Air Service (SAS)**. Nineteen hostages were set free, but one died and two were injured in the cross-fire.

On September 22, **Iraq** invaded **Iran** sparking a bitter eight-year war, which destabilized the whole region. By the end of October, **Khorramshahr**, the largest port in Iran, fell to Iraqi forces.

Under President Tito's grip (see 1943), **Yugoslavia** had achieved internal peace. **Tito's death**, on May 4, combined with the decline of communist ideology, led to the weakening of Yugoslavia's unifying factors. Ethnic and

nationalist differences flared, and individual republics began pushing for **independence**.

A huge bomb ripped through a railway station in **Bologna**, Italy, on August 2, killing 85 people and injuring hundreds in one of the worst terrorist attacks in Italian history. **Right-wing extremists** were thought to be responsible.

Poland experienced a turning point with the **Gdansk shipyard strike**: the first political mass movement to emerge in the Soviet bloc. On August 30, the Polish government reached an agreement with striking shipyard workers, led by **Lech Walesa**. It authorized the establishment of **Solidarity**, a new trade union free of communist control. Membership rapidly swelled to over 10 million.

Mount St. Helens, a volcano in Washington State, northwest US, **violently erupted** on May 18, spewing a huge cloud of ash. It triggered an earthquake measuring 5.2 on the Richter scale; the north face of the mountain collapsed, and 57 people died.

Ronald Reagan, a former Hollywood actor and Republican governor of California, won the **US presidential election** on November 4, beating Jimmy Carter in a landslide victory. He would go on to serve two terms.

Iran-Iraq War
An Iraqi soldier watches an oil refinery burn during the Iran-Iraq war. Oil fields and refineries were heavily targeted by both sides.

